Faculteit Wetenschappen KU Leuven

Faculty Regulations for the Master's Thesis

The Faculty regulations for the Master’s thesis are an addition to the general examination regulations regarding the Master’s thesis of the two-year Master’s programmes of the Faculty of Science. For the one-year and post-initial Master's programmes , the general guidelines under these regulations apply, except for the time schedules and unless otherwise specified. The Programme Committees (POC’s and OC's) may provide further additions to these regulations particularly in regard to making the procedures to be followed more concrete and bringing forward the final dates for the various phases of the allocation process. They will notify this change to the Faculty POC (FPOC), who may request a revision.

1. Supervisors

All full-time and part-time tenured academic staff members of the KU Leuven who are active within a field of research which fits in with a programme, can supervise Master students. Doctors with a temporary tenure of the KU Leuven may also act as supervisor, in which case a member of the tenured academic staff will also be appointed to stand as guarantor for the continuation of the supervision, in the event that the doctor-supervisor’s mandate ends. A doctor-supervisor can supervise a maximum of three dissertations per year.

Exceptionally, a co-supervisor can be someone who is not affiliated with the KU Leuven, but has extensive expertise in the domain of the dissertation.

In case the Master's thesis is written abroad in the framework of an Erasmus exchange, the same rules for the assigning of the (co)supervisors apply as at KU Leuven, unless an exception is allowed by the FPOC.

In case of an interuniversitary programme a (co)supervisor or reader of one of the partner institutions can be appointed. In this case the same rules for the assigning of the (co)supervisors apply as at KU Leuven, unless an exception is allowed by the FPOC. In any case, it must be ensured that the proportion of the KU Leuven members is significant and in accordance with the agreements made within the programme.

2. Topics

Supervisors and groups of supervisors (research groups, departments and sections) can make suggestions to the (P)OC regarding specific topics and/or research topics (“topics”) for a specific course programme, or a speciality within a course programme. Proposals must be submitted to the Programme Director (or the respective delegate) for discussion during the last meeting before the Christmas holidays. The (P)OC will determine the admissibility of the proposals for the programme. The (P)OC may delegate these tasks to the

master's thesis coordinator, who will then carry them out in consultation with the program director and the (P)OC.

3. Announcement

The course programme will publish a list with the proposed topics no later than the first week of the second semester, or by an earlier final date. The published list will enable students from the first phase of the course programme to familiarize themselves with it and to determine their preference. To this end students can contact supervisors and research units.
Late submissions may be added to the list at a later date.
Students can also provide proposals themselves regarding a potential supervisor and research topic outside the list published by the course programme. For this, a motivated request should be submitted to the (P)OC no later than the eighth week of the second semester. After approval of the request, the (P)OC may appoint a co-supervisor to act as point of contact for the course programme and the Examination Committee regarding this Master's thesis.
If the (P)OC takes on a case that refers to an individual student's Master's thesis, it will act without the student members but with the addition of the ombudsperson.

4. Allocation

After announcing the list and at the latest by the end of the class weeks in the second semester, students must make their preference known to the (P)OC for the allocation of a research topic. They must choose a number of preferred topics to be determined by the (P)OC. The Chair of the (P)OC will consult with the respective Master's thesis coordinator and Head of Department or the respective delegate for the allocation of topics. The former will ensure that the students' preferences are followed as closely as possible, the latter will ensure a reasonable distribution of tasks within that department. The monitoring of sufficient staffing and supervisory capacity is their joint task. If desired, the (P)OC can work out a procedure for this. The final allocation will be approved by the (P)OC and announced to the students no later than immediately after the June deliberation of the first course phase of the Master's programme.
A change of supervisor or topic after the second week of the second course phase of the Master's programme may only be permitted by the Programme Director in consultation with any research unit and/or Head of Department (or delegate) involved.

5. Advancing the Allocation Procedure

If an individual student wishes the procedure to be advanced in connection with a domestic or foreign stay outside of KU Leuven (Erasmus and similar programmes) during the second Master's phase, the student should inform the Faculty Administration and contact the Erasmus coordinator before the Christmas holidays. The Erasmus coordinator will consult with the student, the potential supervisor(s) or the research groups and with the Programme Director. No later than during the second week of the second semester, the student will deliver a dossier to the Erasmus coordinator who will submit this for approval to the (P)OC.

6. Language of the Master's Thesis

For the initial Master programmes, the Master's thesis is completed in the language of the programme: for the English-taught Masters in English, for the Dutch-taught Masters in Dutch. Exceptionally, this can be deviated from for the Dutch-taught programme, if the Master's thesis is part of an international exchange.

7. Conclusion of the Second Course Phase of the Master's Programme

The supervisor will notify the secretary of the Examination Committee of the title of the Master's thesis no later than the tenth study week of the second semester. The latter will supply all information regarding the Master's thesis (name of the supervisor, two readers and title of the Master's thesis - English and Dutch) to the Faculty Administration before the end of the thirteenth class week of the second semester.

8. Format and Assessment of the Master's Thesis

The Master's thesis will be submitted electronically via KU Loket (procedure) by the date determined by the (P)OC and no later than three weeks before the deliberation date of the first, second or third examination period respectively. The students submit an electronic copy to the supervisors and the readers, either as an e-mail attachment or via a link to the web page from where the manuscript can be downloaded. If the students do not have the necessary contact details from the readers, this information can be requested from the Master's thesis coordinator. The Master's thesis coordinator communicates the procedure of the programme to the students.
The supervisor will propose two readers from among the potential programme supervisors to the coordinator of the Master's thesis no later than eight weeks before announcement of the results of the second examination period. At least one of these readers will belong to another research unit than the one in which the student prepared the Master's thesis. As an exception, the second reader can be someone that is not attached to the KU Leuven, but has a broad experience in the domain of the Master's thesis or is an emeritus with teaching assignment. A person who is a copromotor cannot be a reader of that thesis. The Master's thesis coordinator must approve this choice. In order to enable a profound assessment, the readers will interview the students on their work. The supervisor and the readers must be official members of the Master's thesis assessment committee.
The student will publicly defend the Master's thesis during the examination period. The coordinator of the Master's thesis will in good time set up an agenda for defending the Master's thesis. The purpose of the agenda is to enable as many professors and researchers from inside or outside the KU Leuven and who are involved in the relevant research area as possible to attend the defence. The examiners who are present at the defence, including the readers of the Master's thesis, will jointly give an examination mark for each defence on a session that is presided over by the Chair of the Examination Committee or the delegate. The names of these examiners will be stated in the report. The supervisor of the Master's thesis collects all examination results. Four marks will be given for the Master's thesis, one from the supervisor, one from both the readers and one for the defence. The relative weight of these four marks is 10:3:3:4. The relative weight of the marks for the Master's thesis for the Master of Geography (interuniversity programme) is 8:4:4:4. In the Master of Space Studies the relative weight is 8:3:3:6.

The student has to obtain a pass on the result of the supervisor, on the average of the results of the readers

(holding into account the rounding rules) and on the defence, in order to succeed for the Master's thesis. In case of a non-tolerable fail (i.c. ≤ 7/20) for one of the readers and a mark of >11/20 for the other reader, both readers discuss if the student can pass or not and justify their decision. If a consensus cannot be reached, the reader marks will be retained, but the student will be considered to have passed this part of the evaluation.

9. Not Passing the Master’s Thesis (Failing Mark or NA)

A student who fails to pass the Master's thesis after the second examination period (failing mark or NA (i.e. exam not taken)) may retake in the third examination period. For students who failed the Master's thesis, the evaluators of the Master's thesis will decide in consultation with the Master's thesis coordinator what the student needs to redo in the third examination period. This may include obtaining additional research results, rewriting or further elaborating the Master’s thesis manuscript and/or (re)defending the Master's thesis orally.

A student who fails to pass the Master’s thesis after the third examination period (failing mark or NA) will have to re-enroll in the Master’s thesis in the following academic year. The supervisor will decide in consultation with the Master’s thesis coordinator whether the Master’s thesis topic can be retained. If it is decided to keep the topic, however, there is the possibility of discontinuing the experimental part due to the cost of practical work.

If a student has not passed the Master's thesis after a second enrollment and thus has to enroll in the Master's thesis for a third time, a supervisor has the right to stop the supervision and release the topic. The student will then be given a new topic and possibly a new supervisor. This is discussed with the Programme Director, the Master's thesis coordinator, the research groups involved and/or the Head(s) of Department (or delegates).

10. Duo Master’s Theses

A duo Master's thesis is a Master's thesis carried out by two students. The students can be enrolled in the same or in different programmes of the Faculty of Science or another faculty. Each student follows the Master’s thesis regulations that apply within their own programme/faculty.

A duo Master's thesis can take different forms but must always meet two criteria: 1) There should be sufficient collaboration between the two students, in all cases for answering a shared research question and optionally also for joint data collection. 2) There should be clear individual input from each student, for example under the form of their own research question and/or individual data collection.

Each student either submits an own Master’s thesis manuscript, or the two students submit a joint Master’s thesis that bundles both jointly and individually written texts. In either case, the students must have written a reasonable proportion of the Master’s thesis independently of each other to allow the students to be evaluated separately. Also, in both cases, it should be clearly stated what everyone's contribution was to the different parts of the Master’s thesis. On the title page, the names of both students should be listed. At the beginning of each chapter it should be stated who contributed to the chapter. When students submit a joint thesis manuscript as part of a duo master's project, the title must be identical. This is to avoid issues during the

plagiarism screening process using Turnitin.

A duo Master's thesis cannot be started if it is clear from the start that the two students cannot defend in the same examination period.

The guiding team includes at least one supervisor, possibly assisted by one or more daily mentors. If the two students are from different programmes or research groups, it may be appropriate to work with two supervisors.

The two students are best evaluated by the same Assessment Committee, i.e. the same readers evaluate the manuscript(s), the students defend before the same Defence Committee, and if there are two supervisors, ideally both should be member of the Defence Committee. Each student defends the Master's thesis individually. If possible, the two students do not attend each other's defence and defend their Master's thesis right after each other, getting more or less the same questions about the joint part in the Master’s thesis.

Marks are given after the two students have defended their Master's thesis. For a duo Master's thesis, the same evaluation criteria, scoring rules and evaluation rubric apply as for an individual Master's thesis. If there are two supervisors, they agree on a joint mark. A separate evaluation rubric is completed for each student.

If one of the two students does not pass the duo Master's thesis, this must be thoroughly justified. The Examination Committee, based on the advice of the Master's thesis coordinator and supervisor, decides whether the student can continue to work individually on the same Master’s thesis topic or needs to choose a new topic.

11. Exception relating to the Master’s Programmes in Applied Informatics

Students of the Master's programmes Applied Informatics will follow the procedures in effect in the Computer Science Department within the Faculty of Engineering concerning the submission of the application, the allocation of the research group, the supervisor and the readers.
These regulations will also enable students to complete their Master's thesis on Applied Informatics outside the Computer Science Department.
The Head of the Computer Science Department (or the respective delegate) will provide all information regarding the Master’s thesis (name of the supervisor and title of the Master's thesis) no later than eight weeks before the date on which the results are announced to the Faculty Administration.

12. Amendments and Disputes

All disputes arising from the application of these regulations will be settled by the Programme Director who is in charge of the course programme, if necessary in consultation with the respective Heads of Department. Any appeals against this decision must be submitted to the Faculty Board.

Laatste update 09-09-2025

Reacties op inhoud en toegankelijkheid: Faculteit Wetenschappen KU Leuven

Inloggen

Faculteit Wetenschappen

› Reglement